High-Yield Revision Sheet: Food Security in India

Subject: Indian Economy & Social Welfare | NCERT Class 9 Ch. 4 | UPSC Core

⚡ 30-Second Snapshot

- **Food security** requires the simultaneous satisfaction of three dimensions: **availability, accessibility, and affordability**.
- Amartya Sen's **entitlement approach** demonstrates that starvation and famines like the **1943 Bengal Famine** often result from a failure of access and purchasing power rather than absolute physical food shortages.
- India's food security system rests on two main pillars: **Buffer Stocks** managed by the Food Corporation of India (FCI) via **Minimum Support Prices (MSP)**, and the **Public Distribution System (PDS)**.
- The PDS has evolved from universal coverage to **Targeted PDS (TPDS)** and the legal entitlements established under the **National Food Security Act (NFSA) of 2013**.
- **Cooperatives** (such as Amul, Mother Dairy, and ADS Grain Banks) play a vital complementary role in decentralized food and nutrition security.

🏛 Core Concepts & Institutional Frameworks

Institutional Pillar / Concept	Operational Definition & Characteristics	Key Structural & Functional Sub-Types	Socio-Economic & Welfare Significance
Dimensions of Security	Simultaneous availability, physical accessibility, and economic affordability of food.	Production stocks, distribution networks, and household purchasing power.	Prevents malnutrition, chronic hunger, and acute starvation across populations.
Buffer Stock System	Government reserve storage managed by the FCI to stabilize prices and manage emergencies.	Minimum Support Prices (MSP) and subsidised Issue Prices.	Protects farmers from price crashes while maintaining national food reserves.
Public Distribution System	Retail distribution of essential commodities through a nationwide network of fair price shops.	Antyodaya, BPL, and APL ration cards; NFSA 2013 legal entitlements.	Acts as the primary safety net shielding vulnerable populations from market volatility.
Cooperative Networks	Community-led and cooperative institutional models supporting food and dairy supply chains.	Amul, Mother Dairy, and Academy of Development Science (ADS) grain banks.	Enhances decentralized supply resilience and empowers local producers.

📐 Comparative Matrix: Chronic vs. Seasonal Hunger

- **Chronic Hunger:**
  - **Causes & Nature:** Results from diets persistently inadequate in quantity or quality due to consistently low income and poverty.
  - **Vulnerable Groups:** Destitutes, chronic casual laborers, and landless rural poor.
- **Seasonal Hunger:**
  - **Causes & Nature:** Tied to agricultural cycles (rural planting gaps) or employment fluctuations in urban casual labor markets.
  - **Vulnerable Groups:** Agricultural casual laborers and construction workers during off-seasons.

⚠ Common UPSC Exam Traps

- **Trap 1 (Availability vs. Access):** Food security is not achieved merely by producing surplus grain; *physical availability must be matched by economic accessibility and affordability* for every citizen.
- **Trap 2 (Bengal Famine Cause):** The 1943 Bengal famine was not caused by a total collapse of physical rice production; *it was driven by an entitlement failure* involving rising prices, hoarding, and collapsing wages.
- **Trap 3 (PDS Evolution):** PDS has not remained static or universal; *it shifted from universal*

coverage to targeted pricing under TPDS in 1997 and legal entitlements under NFSA 2013.

- **Trap 4 (MSP Function):** Minimum Support Prices do not set consumer retail prices; *they act as a price floor* paid to farmers by the government during procurement.
- **Trap 5 (Role of Cooperatives):** Cooperatives are not restricted to north India; *they are especially prominent in southern and western India* (e.g., Tamil Nadu cooperatives and Gujarat's Amul).

🎯 High-Yield Facts Box

Economic Feature	Governing Mechanism	Diagnostic Identifier
Entitlement Approach	Amartya Sen's economic theory	Framework proving famines arise from loss of command over food via production, exchange, or state provisioning.
Minimum Support Price	Government price floor	Pre-announced procurement price protecting farmers from market price crashes.
Antyodaya Anna Yojana	Targeted welfare scheme	Programme launched in 2000 providing heavily subsidised foodgrains to the poorest of the poor.
NFSA 2013	Legal rights framework	Legislation covering 75% of rural and 50% of urban populations with legal food entitlements.
ADS Grain Banks	Community food security	NGO-supported decentralized grain storage network established in Maharashtra.

📝 Prelims Practice Challenge

Q1. Consider the following statements regarding food security and the entitlement approach in India:

1. Food security requires the simultaneous satisfaction of availability, accessibility, and affordability dimensions.
2. Amartya Sen's entitlement approach argues that famines are exclusively caused by absolute physical shortages of food grain production within a country.
3. Chronic hunger stems from diets persistently inadequate in quantity or quality due to consistently low household incomes.
4. Seasonal hunger is closely tied to agricultural growing cycles in rural areas and employment demand fluctuations in urban casual labor markets.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (A) 1, 3, and 4 only
- (B) 2 and 3 only
- (C) 1, 2, and 4 only
- (D) 1, 2, 3, and 4

> **Answer: (A) 1, 3, and 4 only**
> **Explanation:** Statements 1, 3, and 4 are correct descriptions of food security dimensions, chronic hunger, and seasonal hunger. Statement 2 is incorrect because Sen's entitlement approach specifically shows that *famines often occur due to failure of access and entitlements* (such as inflation or wage collapse) even when aggregate food availability does not collapse.

Q2. With reference to India's food security system, consider the following statements:

1. The Food Corporation of India (FCI) procures foodgrains from farmers at pre-announced Minimum Support Prices (MSP).
2. The Targeted Public Distribution System (TPDS) introduced in 1997 established differentiated pricing for Below Poverty Line (BPL) and Above Poverty Line (APL) families.
3. The National Food Security Act (NFSA) enacted in 2013 covers up to 75 percent of the rural population and 50 percent of the urban population.
4. Cooperative societies play no role in public distribution or food security management in India.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- (A) 1, 2, and 3 only
- (B) 1 and 4 only
- (C) 2, 3, and 4 only
- (D) 1, 2, 3, and 4

Answer: (A) 1, 2, and 3 only
Explanation: Statements 1, 2, and 3 are correct regarding FCI procurement, TPDS pricing tiers, and NFSA coverage percentages. Statement 4 is incorrect because *cooperative societies play a major role* in food security (e.g., managing fair price shops in Tamil Nadu, Mother Dairy, and ADS grain banks).

🖉 Mains Practice Question (10 Marks / 150 Words)

Question: *"Examine the multi-dimensional nature of food security in India. Discuss the structural bottlenecks in buffer stock management and evaluate the impact of the Public Distribution System in ensuring nutritional and economic welfare."*

Structured Answer Framework:

- **Introduction (25–30 words):**
  Define food security through its three core pillars (availability, accessibility, and affordability) and highlight its foundational role in human capital development and poverty eradication.
- **Body Arguments (80–90 words):**
  - *Buffer Stock Bottlenecks:* Analyze how rising MSPs, high storage and transportation costs, and grain spoilage in overflowing FCI godowns create fiscal and logistical strains.
  - *PDS Impact & Reforms:* Discuss the evolution of the PDS towards targeted distribution (TPDS) and legal entitlements under NFSA 2013, noting its success in stabilizing national prices while addressing leakage, corruption, and nutritional gaps.
- **Conclusion / Way Forward (25–30 words):**
  Enhancing food security requires modernizing storage infrastructure, promoting decentralized procurement, integrating nutrition-focused welfare schemes, and expanding community cooperative networks.

✍ Notes & Updates